The Zombie Argument

David Chalmers, the hard problem of consciousness, and three responses

This workbook consolidates what you have covered in the slideshow and handout. Work through it in order, or jump to the part you need. Every task can be done on your own, so if you missed a lesson you can still catch up. Answers to the recall tasks are at the back: try first, then check.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

In this workbook

1. Where am I now? A self-check
2. Key terms
3. Quick recall
4. Argument reconstruction
5. Objections and evaluation
6. Exam practice (3, 5, 12 and 25 marks)
7. Answers

> **Key Thesis**
> It is **conceivable** that there could be a **zombie**: a being physically identical to a conscious human, molecule for molecule, that behaves identically but has **no conscious experience**. There is nothing it is like to be a zombie. If zombies are conceivable they are metaphysically possible, and if they are possible, consciousness is **not physical** (David Chalmers).

Part 01 Where am I now?

How to use this section

Tick a column for each statement **before** you start, then again **when you finish**. Green = I could explain it to someone else. Amber = I half get it. Red = not yet.

I can...	Start	End
define a philosophical zombie precisely	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain the hard problem of consciousness	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
set out the zombie argument in standard form	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
distinguish logical, physical and metaphysical possibility	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain the three responses (not conceivable; conceivable but not possible; possible worlds and the actual world)	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
connect the argument to property dualism	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
reach and defend a judgement on the zombie argument	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G

Part 02 Key terms

Task 1 · Match the term to its definition

Write the letter of the correct definition next to each term.

Term	Letter
Philosophical zombie	
Hard problem of consciousness	
Conceivable	
Logically possible	
Physically possible	
Metaphysically possible	
Type-A materialism	
Possible world	

	Definition
A	The view that zombies are not even conceivable; on reflection, a physical duplicate must be conscious.
B	Could genuinely have been so, given the real natures of things (true in some possible world).
C	Coherently imaginable, with no contradiction revealed even on reflection.
D	A complete way things could have been.
E	Explaining how and why physical processes give rise to subjective experience.
F	Consistent with the actual laws of nature.
G	A being physically and behaviourally identical to a conscious human but with no conscious experience.
H	Involves no contradiction, e.g. jumping over Everest (unlike a square circle).

Task 2 · Fill the gaps

Use the word bank. Each word is used once.

Key idea Word bank: behaviour · conceivability · physical · hard · like · physically · possibility · A · H_2O

Chalmers calls the problem of experience the _____ problem of consciousness. A zombie is _____ identical to a conscious being, and its _____ is indistinguishable, but there is nothing it is _____ to be it. The argument moves from _____ to metaphysical _____ to the conclusion that consciousness is not _____. Type-_____ materialists deny zombies are conceivable at all. Others say that water could not have been anything but _____, so conceivability is a poor guide to possibility.

Task 3 · In your own words

Describe your zombie twin. What is the same about it, and what is missing? Why can no one else tell the difference?

Part 03 Quick recall

How to use this section

Answer from memory first. Then check your notes, and add anything you missed in a different colour. That second colour shows you exactly what to revise.

1. Where did Chalmers develop the zombie argument?

2. What is the hard problem of consciousness?

3. Do zombies need to exist for the argument to work?

4. State the four steps of the argument.

5. Give an example of something logically possible but physically impossible.

6. What is the 2+2=5 comparison meant to show?

7. How does water/H_2O challenge premise 2?

8. State the third response.

Part 04 Argument reconstruction

> **How to use this section**
> Each argument below has been jumbled. Number the lines into the right order (premises first, conclusion last). Then answer the questions underneath. Being able to set out an argument in standard form is exactly what the 5-mark and 12-mark questions reward.

Chalmers' zombie argument

> *'There is nothing it is like to be a Zombie'*
> — David Chalmers, *as quoted on your slides*

Order	Jumbled line
	If it is metaphysically possible that there are zombies, then consciousness is not physical.
	If it is conceivable that there are zombies, it is metaphysically possible that there are zombies.
	It is conceivable that there be zombies.
	Therefore, consciousness is non-physical.

→ Match each of the three responses to the premise it attacks.

→ Why does premise 3 follow? (Hint: if consciousness *were* physical, a full physical duplicate would have to be conscious.)

The 'conceivable but not possible' response

Order	Jumbled line
	Therefore, the zombie argument fails at premise 2.
	So the conceivability of zombies does not show they are possible.
	Identity statements like 'water is H_2O' are necessary: true in every possible world.
	So conceivability does not guarantee metaphysical possibility.

Order	Jumbled line
	Water is H_2O.
	Yet it seems conceivable that water is not H_2O.

→ How might Chalmers say we are really imagining 'watery stuff', not water itself?

→ Why is the consciousness case arguably different from the water case?

Part 05 Objections and evaluation

How to use this section

For each objection: explain the problem in your own words, write the best response, then judge whether the response works. The hint column is there if you are stuck; cover it up if you want a harder challenge.

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Zombies are not conceivable (type-A)	Like 'thinking' 2+2=5.			
Conceivable but not possible	Water/H_2O; leaping Everest.			
Possible worlds tell us nothing about the actual world	Only our world exists.			

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Zombie behaviour is suspicious	Zombie-Chalmers writes books about consciousness.			
Leads to epiphenomenalism	If zombies behave identically, consciousness does no causal work.			

Ranking the objections

Which objection is the **most** damaging, and which is the **least**? Justify your choice: a strong objection attacks a key premise and is hard to answer.

Most damaging: _____ because...

Least damaging: _____ because...

Building a judgement

Does the zombie argument prove that consciousness is non-physical? Focus on the move from conceivability to possibility.

Key idea Sentence starters: *The strongest argument for this view is... because...* · *However, this is undermined by...* · *A defender might reply that... but this fails / succeeds because...* · *Therefore, on balance...*

Part 06

Exam practice

How to use this section

On Paper 2 the **3-, 5- and 12-mark** questions test **AO1** only: knowledge and understanding, shown through precise, accurate explanation. The **25-mark** question is **5 marks AO1 + 20 marks AO2**: you must argue, evaluate and reach a judgement that your essay supports throughout.

Spend roughly a minute per mark. Plan before you write.

3 marks · What is meant by a 'philosophical zombie'?

Key idea AO1 · A precise definition or short point. One or two accurate sentences; no evaluation needed.

5 marks · Explain the philosophical zombies argument for property dualism.

Key idea AO1 · Set out the idea or argument clearly and in logical order. Precise terminology; a standard-form layout often works best.

Planning frame

1. Define a zombie (physical and behavioural duplicate, no consciousness).
2. Premise 1: zombies are conceivable.
3. Premise 2: so metaphysically possible.
4. Premise 3 and conclusion: consciousness is not physical, so property dualism.

12 marks · Explain how the claim that 'what is conceivable may not be metaphysically possible' challenges the zombie argument.

Key idea AO1 · A full, precise explanation. Show how the ideas connect logically, step by step. Do **not** evaluate: explain.

Planning frame

1. Set out the zombie argument in standard form.
2. Distinguish conceivability from metaphysical possibility.
3. Use water/H_2O to show they can come apart.
4. Show this blocks premise 2, so the conclusion does not follow.

25 marks · Does the zombie argument show that physicalism is false?

Key idea AO1 (5) + AO2 (20) · State your line of argument in the introduction and keep to it. Every paragraph should argue, not just describe: point → objection → response → mini-judgement. End with a conclusion that follows from what you have argued.

Model structure

Section	What to do	My plan
Introduction	Define the key terms. State your thesis: the answer you will defend.	
Paragraph 1	The hard problem and the argument's force → mini-judgement.	

Section	What to do	My plan
Paragraph 2	Response 1: zombies are not conceivable → Chalmers' reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 3	Response 2: conceivable but not possible → Chalmers' reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 4	Response 3: possible worlds and the actual world → reply → mini-judgement.	
Conclusion	Restate your judgement and explain **why** the balance of argument supports it. No new arguments.	

Write your essay on lined paper, or continue below.

Reflect

Go back to Part 01 and fill in the **End** column. Which statement is still red or amber? Write one specific thing you will do about it.

Part 07 Answers

How to use this section

Use these to check Parts 02–04. Exam answers are not given here: bring them to your teacher, or mark against the AO guidance.

Task 1 · Matching

Philosophical zombie = G · Hard problem of consciousness = E · Conceivable = C · Logically possible = H · Physically possible = F · Metaphysically possible = B · Type-A materialism = A · Possible world = D

Task 2 · Gaps

(1) hard · (2) physically · (3) behaviour · (4) like · (5) conceivability · (6) possibility · (7) physical · (8) A · (9) H_2O

Quick recall

1. 'Consciousness and its Place in Nature' and *The Conscious Mind*.
2. How and why physical processes give rise to subjective experience: why there is something it is like to be us.
3. No: they need only be conceivable (and so, it is claimed, possible).
4. Zombies are conceivable → so metaphysically possible → if possible, consciousness is not physical → consciousness is non-physical.
5. Jumping over Everest in one leap.
6. We can seem to think something coherent while actually being confused; so too with zombies (type-A materialism).
7. Water without H_2O seems conceivable, yet if water is H_2O it is H_2O in every possible world; so conceivability ≠ possibility.
8. What is metaphysically possible tells us nothing about the actual world; other possible worlds are irrelevant to ours.

Arguments in order

Chalmers' zombie argument

1. It is conceivable that there be zombies.
2. If it is conceivable that there are zombies, it is metaphysically possible that there are zombies.
3. If it is metaphysically possible that there are zombies, then consciousness is not physical.
4. Therefore, consciousness is non-physical.

The 'conceivable but not possible' response

1. Water is H_2O.
2. Identity statements like 'water is H_2O' are necessary: true in every possible world.
3. Yet it seems conceivable that water is not H_2O.

4. So conceivability does not guarantee metaphysical possibility.
5. So the conceivability of zombies does not show they are possible.
6. Therefore, the zombie argument fails at premise 2.

Objections: model responses

Objection	Possible response
Zombies are not conceivable (type-A)	Chalmers: there is no contradiction even on careful reflection; the burden is on the materialist to show one.
Conceivable but not possible	Chalmers: with water we imagine 'watery stuff'; with consciousness the appearance just is the thing, so no such gap.
Possible worlds tell us nothing about the actual world	Chalmers: if consciousness *were* physical, it would be so necessarily; one possible zombie world shows it is not.
Zombie behaviour is suspicious	Accept it: this pushes towards epiphenomenalism, with its own costs.
Leads to epiphenomenalism	Bite the bullet, or seek an interactionist property dualism.